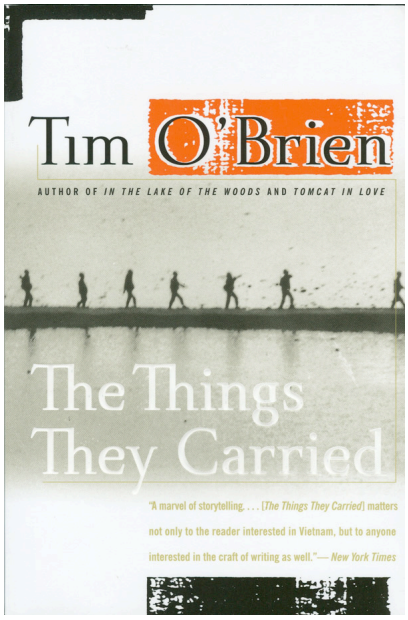
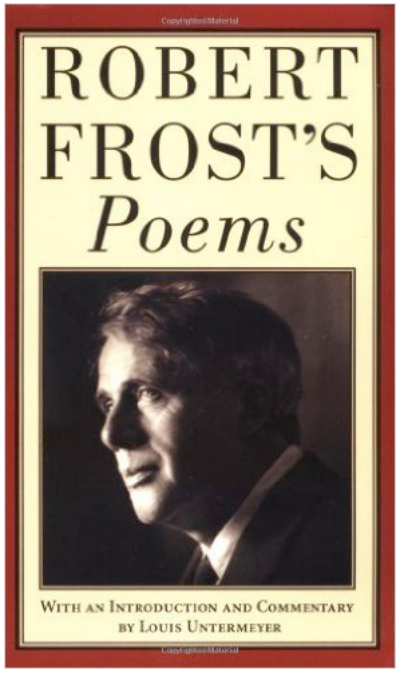
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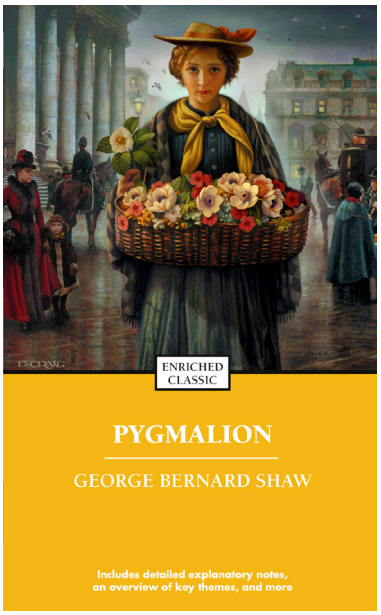
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

State • 2016







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • State • 2016

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The quotation that appears on the title page of a book or as, for instance, a motto heading a section of a work is an
   A) epigone.
   B) epigram.
   C) epigraph.
   D) epitaph.
   E) epithet.

2. One of the founders of New Criticism and recipient of the 1947 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his *roman à clef All the King's Men* is
   A) Edwin Arlington Robinson.
   B) William Styron.
   C) Robert Penn Warren.
   D) William Carlos Williams.
   E) Thornton Wilder.

3. A name that is significant to a narrative's meaning is called a(n)
   A) allonym.
   B) ananym.
   C) heteronym.
   D) *redende name*.
   E) transferred epithet.

4. The twentieth-century Irish author of *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, *Ulysses*, *Dubliners*, and *Finnegans Wake* is
   A) J. P. Donleavy.
   B) James Joyce.
   C) Laurence Sterne.
   D) Bram Stoker.
   E) William Trevor.

5. A type of metaphor that uses a deliberate discrepancy of connotation between the tenor and the vehicle, especially in its use of a pejorative vehicle in reference to a tenor of value and desirability, is the
   A) dead metaphor.
   B) diminishing metaphor.
   C) extended metaphor.
   D) mixed metaphor.
   E) synecdochic metaphor.

6. A short lyric usually dealing with love or a pastoral theme and designed for—or at least suitable for—a musical setting is the
   A) aubade.
   B) elegy.
   C) epithalamium.
   D) madrigal.
   E) masque.

7. The reversal of fortune for a protagonist—possibly either a fall, as in a tragedy, or a success, as in a comedy—is known as
   A) aporia.
   B) catharsis.
   C) hamartia.
   D) hubris.
   E) peripety.

8. **Not** a *mixed figure* featuring an incongruous mingling of figures of speech is the statement
   A) A photon struck him**;** lightning is for greater men.
   B) He's burning the midnight oil from both ends.
   C) I can read him like the back of my book.
   D) I wouldn't eat that with a ten-foot pole.
   E) We have to get all our ducks on the same page.

9. The early twentieth-century American author of *The House of Mirth*, *The Marne*, *The Age of Innocence*, and *Ethan Frome* is
   A) Willa Cather.
   B) Harper Lee.
   C) Ursula K. Le Guin.
   D) Alice Walker.
   E) Edith Wharton.

10. The derogatory title applied by *Blackwood's Magazine* to a group of nineteenth-century British writers, including William Hazlitt, Leigh Hunt, and John Keats, because of their alleged poor taste in such matters as diction and rhyme is the
    A) Cockney School.
    B) Lake School.
    C) Martian School.
    D) Satanic School.
    E) Spasmodics.

11. The levels traditionally used in interpreting scriptural and allegorical material, the literal, the allegorical, the moral, and the analogical, are known as (the)

A) *explication de texte*.
B) four elements.
C) four major tropes.
D) four senses of interpretation.
E) Freytag's pyramid.

12. The author of *Trifles* and recipient of the 1931 Pulitzer Prize for Drama for her play *Alison's House* is

A) Susan Glaspell.
B) Lorraine Hansberry.
C) Lillian Hellman.
D) Suzan-Lori Parks.
E) Paula Vogel.

13. The Persian born British author who spent most of her life in southern Africa and wrote *The Golden Notebook*, *Memoirs of a Survivor*, *The Sirian Experiments*, "The Story of a Non-Marrying Man," and the frequently anthologized short stories "To Room Nineteen" and "Through the Tunnel," is

A) Margaret Atwood.
B) Aminatta Forna.
C) Nadine Gordimer.
D) Doris Lessing.
E) Sarah Ladipo Manyika.

14. A French term for a professional musical entertainer of medieval times who not only sang or recited ballads and stories written by others but sometimes composed songs and other forms of entertainment is

A) bard.
B) *filidh*.
C) *jongleur*.
D) *poète maudit*.
E) scop.

15. The group of critics, including Georges Poulet, Albert Béguin, and Marcel Raymond, who see a literary work as a series of existential expressions of the author's individual consciousness is the

A) Decadents.
B) Geneva School.
C) Imagists.
D) Parnassians.
E) Symbolists.

16. The use of repetitious words in which an idea is repeated without any added force or clarity is called

A) antithesis.
B) hyperbole.
C) redaction.
D) tautology.
E) zeugma.

17. **Not** among the works of the twentieth-century American playwright Tennessee Williams is

A) *Death of a Salesman.*
B) *The Glass Menagerie*.
C) *The Night of the Iguana*.
D) *The Rose Tattoo*.
E) *A Streetcar Named Desire*.

18. The period between the Jacksonian Era and the close of the Civil War that saw the testing of a nation and its development by ordeal and which was characterized by westward expansion, the increasing gravity of the slavery question, and the impulse toward reform in the North is the

A) Naturalistic and Symbolistic Period.
B) Period of Conformity and Criticism.
C) Postmodern Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

19. The term that embodies the application of the principles of scientific determinism in literature, which, in turn, characterizes a literary movement of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, is

A) Darwinism.
B) Erastianism.
C) Naturalism.
D) Objectivism.
E) Surrealism.

20. The sameness or similarity of endings in consecutive words or words near each other—often considered unsettling or graceless but sometimes unavoidable—is called

A) homeoptoton.
B) homeoteleuton.
C) homostrophic structure.
D) parallelism.
E) parataxis.

21. The overarching term for a narrator who may be in error in his or her understanding or report of things and who thus leaves readers without the guides needed for making judgments is

A) first-person narrator.
B) intrusive narrator.
C) naïve narrator.
D) putative author.
E) unreliable narrator.

22. The author of "Richard Cory" and recipient of the 1922, 1925, and 1928 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry is

A) Stephen Vincent Benét.
B) John Gould Fletcher.
C) Edwin Arlington Robinson.
D) William Carlos Williams.
E) Franz Wright.

23. The belief that everything partakes of a hierarchical system, extending upward from inanimate matter to man, to angels, and finally, to God, is known as (the)

A) animism.
B) Great Chain of Being.
C) hieronymy.
D) pantheism.
E) pantisocracy.

24. An overarching term describing one or another of the poetic genres that are characteristically short, though there are exceptions, and possess marked descriptive, narrative, and pastoral qualities is

A) dirge.
B) idyll.
C) jeremiad.
D) panegyric.
E) threnody.

25. The group of writers, including F. Scott Fitzgerald, Erich Maria Remarque, and Ernest Hemingway, who were born around 1900, some serving in WWI, and who also reacted against certain tendencies of older writers in the 1920s is known as the

A) Agrarians.
B) Lost Generation.
C) Muckrakers.
D) Pre-Raphaelites.
E) Transcendental Club.

26. The period in English literature between 1100 and 1350, which is also often called the Early Middle English Period and is frequently dated from the Conquest in 1066, is known as the

A) Anglo-Norman Period.
B) Early Tudor Age.
C) Early Victorian Age.
D) Middle English Period.
E) Neoclassic Period.

27. **Not** a genre that is, in some manner, a commemoration of a death is (the)

A) dirge.
B) elegy.
C) lament.
D) scat.
E) threnody.

28. The author of *Main Street*, *Babbitt*, *Arrowsmith*, and *It Can't Happen Here* and recipient of the 1930 Nobel Prize for Literature is

A) Sinclair Lewis.
B) Eugene O'Neill.
C) Upton Sinclair.
D) Isaac Bashevis Singer.
E) John Steinbeck.

29. Greek comedy of the fifth century BCE, performed at festivals of Dionysus, that blends religious ceremony, satire, wit, and buffoonery, is

A) Menippean satire.
B) New Comedy.
C) Old Comedy.
D) philippic.
E) satyr play.

30. A form of drama that before 1890 or so had been used chiefly on vaudeville programs and as curtain raisers in the legitimate theater and, since the Little Theater Movement, has been adapted by playwrights of high quality is (the)

A) Dogme 95.
B) drawing room comedy.
C) masque.
D) minstrel show.
E) one-act play.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with George Bernard Shaw's *Pygmalion*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Tim O'Brien's *The Things They Carried*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Robert Frost's poetry (selected).

31. In George Bernard Shaw's *Pygmalion*, the script's commentary, "Higgins thus scolded, subsides. The hurricane is succeeded by a zephyr of amiable surprise," exemplifies (a/n)
    A) controlling image.
    B) esemplastic threshold.
    C) jumping the shark.
    D) prolegomenon.
    E) syzygy.

32. **Not** among the comparisons or references to which Eliza is likened at Earl's Court is (a)
    A) Hungarian princess.
    B) Lillie Langtry.
    C) morganatic offspring.
    D) my fair lady.
    E) Queen Victoria.

33. Higgins's assessment of Alfred Doolittle's dialect, "Sentimental rhetoric! thats the Welsh strain in him. It also accounts for his mendacity and dishonesty," drifts quickly, perhaps characteristically, into
    A) scribal error.
    B) sentimentalism.
    C) showing versus telling.
    D) stereotyping.
    E) stichomythia.

34. The *difficulty* to which Higgins refers when Pickering and he discuss the experiment that is to be Eliza is/are Eliza's
    A) gesticulations.
    B) grammar
    C) habiliments.
    D) in-laws.
    E) mere pronunciation.

35. "Would the world ever have been made if its maker had been afraid of making trouble? Making life means making trouble. Theres only one way of escaping trouble; and thats killing things" is
    A) Higgins's response to Alfred Doolittle.
    B) Higgins's response to Freddy Eynsford Hill.
    C) Higgins's response to Liza.
    D) Higgins's response to Mrs. Pearce.
    E) Higgins's response to Pickering.

36. Shaw's *Pygmalion*, especially in terms of how the playwright handles the stories upon which the play is built, including especially the original Pygmalion story, reflects his
    A) early feminism.
    B) egalitarianism.
    C) lifelong misogyny.
    D) socialism.
    E) unrepentant xenophobia.

37. In O'Brien's *The Things They Carried*, the line "They were called legs or grunts" models (the)
    A) alienation effect.
    B) apostrophe.
    C) litotes.
    D) pathetic fallacy.
    E) synecdoche.

38. The character whose attitude regarding the situation unfolding is reflected perfectly in the declaration "I'm here[;] I might as well learn something" is
    A) Mary Anne Bell.
    B) Elroy Berdahl.
    C) Jimmy Cross.
    D) Curt Lemon.
    E) Tim O'Brien.

39. Kiowa's mockingly cynical observation, "Tim it's a *war*. The guy wasn't Heidi—he had a weapon, right?" depends on a
    A) biblical allusion.
    B) classical allusion.
    C) historical allusion.
    D) literary allusion.
    E) topical allusion.

40. O'Brien falls "asleep during the second reel [of a Jane Fonda movie] and forty minutes later [he wakes] up to a sore ass and a foul temper," the imagery of which is, rhetorically, an example of
    A) hyperbole.
    B) metonymy.
    C) oxymoron.
    D) synæsthesia.
    E) zeugma.

41. The "chapter" in which O'Brien takes his daughter to Vietnam is entitled

A) Church.
B) Enemies.
C) Field Trip.
D) In the Field.
E) On the Rainy River.

42. Topical allusions to movies pervade O'Brien's work; **not** among the movies, reference to which is poignantly purposeful, is

A) *Barbarella*.
B) *The Birds*.
C) *Bonnie and Clyde*.
D) *The Man Who Never Was*.
E) *Saving Private Ryan*.

Items 43-45 refer to Robert Frost's

Birches

When I see birches bend to left and right
Across the lines of straighter darker trees,
I like to think some boy's been swinging them.
But swinging doesn't bend them down to stay
As ice-storms do. Often you must have seen them
Loaded with ice a sunny winter morning
After a rain. They click upon themselves
As the breeze rises, and turn many-colored
As the stir cracks and crazes their enamel.
Soon the sun's warmth makes them shed crystal shells
Shattering and avalanching on the snow-crust—
Such heaps of broken glass to sweep away
You'd think the inner dome of heaven had fallen.
They are dragged to the withered bracken by the load,
And they seem not to break; though once they are bowed
So low for long, they never right themselves:
You may see their trunks arching in the woods
Years afterwards, trailing their leaves on the ground
Like girls on hands and knees that throw their hair
Before them over their heads to dry in the sun.
But I was going to say when Truth broke in
With all her matter-of-fact about the ice-storm
I should prefer to have some boy bend them
As he went out and in to fetch the cows—
Some boy too far from town to learn baseball,
Whose only play was what he found himself,
Summer or winter, and could play alone.
One by one he subdued his father's trees
By riding them down over and over again
Until he took the stiffness out of them,
And not one but hung limp, not one was left
For him to conquer. He learned all there was
To learn about not launching out too soon
And so not carrying the tree away
Clear to the ground. He always kept his poise
To the top branches, climbing carefully
With the same pains you use to fill a cup
Up to the brim, and even above the brim.
Then he flung outward, feet first, with a swish,
Kicking his way down through the air to the ground.
So was I once myself a swinger of birches.
And so I dream of going back to be.
It's when I'm weary of considerations,
And life is too much like a pathless wood
Where your face burns and tickles with the cobwebs
Broken across it, and one eye is weeping
From a twig's having lashed across it open.
I'd like to get away from earth awhile
And then come back to it and begin over.
May no fate willfully misunderstand me
And half grant what I wish and snatch me away
Not to return. Earth's the right place for love:
I don't know where it's likely to go better.
I'd like to go by climbing a birch tree,
And climb black branches up a snow-white trunk
Toward heaven, till the tree could bear no more,
But dipped its top and set me down again.
That would be good both going and coming back.
One could do worse than be a swinger of birches.

43. The theme of Frost's "Birches" can be understood to be addressing the

A) need to return to the natural world.
B) power of nature to distract one from one's chores.
C) relationship between imagination and reality.
D) satisfaction of growing up in a rural area alone.
E) spirit of youth against the extremes of the cold.

44. The comparison found in lines 17-20 is founded on a

A) conceit.
B) kenning.
C) metaphor.
D) paradox.
E) simile.

45. The intrusiveness of Truth (lines 21-22) is an example of

A) apostrophe.
B) pathetic fallacy.
C) personification.
D) preterition.
E) reification.

Items 46-50 refer to Robert Frost's

The Silken Tent

She is as in a field a silken tent
At midday when the sunny summer breeze
Has dried the dew and all its ropes relent,
So that in guys it gently sways at ease,
And its supporting central cedar pole,
That is its pinnacle to heavenward
And signifies the sureness of the soul,
Seems to owe naught to any single cord,
But strictly held by none, is loosely bound
By countless silken ties of love and thought
To everything on earth the compass round,
And only by one's going slightly taut
In the capriciousness of summer air
Is of the slightest bondage made aware.

46. The poetic form of Robert Frost's "The Silken Tent" is the
A) Anglo-Norman sonnet.
B) English sonnet.
C) Italian sonnet.
D) Miltonic sonnet.
E) New England sonnet.

47. The central figure of speech on which Frost's sonnet depends is
A) hyperbole.
B) litotes.
C) metaphor.
D) metonymy.
E) zeugma.

48. Lines 2, 4, 5, 7, 10, and 13, especially, are characterized by
A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) dissonance.
D) sigmatism.
E) synæsthesia.

49. Thematic to Frost's "The Silken Tent" is the notion of
A) capriciousness.
B) poetic sentence structure.
C) pragmatism.
D) relationships.
E) synthesis.

50. The seemingly paradoxical imagery that includes looseness and tautness contributes to the poem's
A) hyperbolic signification.
B) oxymoronic rigidness.
C) semantic tightness.
D) sonnetic threnody.
E) thematic complexity.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-53 refer to Robert Herrick's

Delight in Disorder

A sweet disorder in the dress
Kindles in clothes a wantonness;
A lawn about the shoulders thrown
Into a fine distraction;
An erring lace, which here and there
Enthrals the crimson stomacher;
A cuff neglectful, and thereby
Ribands* to flow confusedly; *ribbons
A winning wave, deserving note,
In the tempestuous petticoat;
A careless shoe-string, in whose tie
I see a wild civility:
Do more bewitch me, than when art
Is too precise in every part.

51. The formula that underscores Herrick's poem, which suggests transitory youth and beauty, is
A) *carpe diem*.
B) *la femme inspiratrice.*
C) *memento mori.*
D) *ubi sunt.*
E) *verbum infans.*

52. The overall metrical pattern of Herrick's poem is
A) iambic dimeter.
B) iambic monometer.
C) iambic pentameter.
D) iambic tetrameter.
E) iambic trimeter.

53. The central conceit, "wild civility," is
A) double-entendric.
B) hyperbolic.
C) metonymic.
D) monovocalic.
E) oxymoronic.

Items 54-58 refer to Edwin Arlington Robinson's

Miniver Cheevy

Miniver Cheevy, child of scorn,
  Grew lean while he assailed the seasons;
He wept that he was ever born,
  And he had reasons.

Miniver loved the days of old
  When swords were bright and steeds were prancing;
The vision of a warrior bold
  Would set him dancing.

Miniver sighed for what was not,
  And dreamed, and rested from his labors;
He dreamed of Thebes and Camelot,
  And Priam's neighbors.

Miniver mourned the ripe renown
  That made so many a name so fragrant;
He mourned Romance, now on the town,
  And Art, a vagrant.

Miniver loved the Medici,
  Albeit he had never seen one;
He would have sinned incessantly
  Could he have been one.

Miniver cursed the commonplace
  And eyed a khaki suit with loathing;
He missed the mediæval grace
  Of iron clothing.

Miniver scorned the gold he sought,
  But sore annoyed was he without it;
Miniver thought, and thought, and thought,
  And thought about it.

Miniver Cheevy, born too late,
  Scratched his head and kept on thinking;
Miniver coughed, and called it fate,
  And kept on drinking.

54. Robinson's Miniver Cheevy is a(n)

A) anachronistic Byronic hero.
B) antithesis of an antihero.
C) frustrated romantic idealist.
D) renegade avatar.
E) young man from the provinces.

55. Thematically, Robinson's poem is an account of a

A) braggadocio's peripety.
B) drunk's demise.
C) hapless man's search for happiness.
D) putative author's intent to be great.
E) reader's escape into history.

56. The second and fourth line of each stanza are characterized by

A) feminine rhyme.
B) identical rhyme.
C) internal rhyme.
D) leonine rhyme.
E) masculine rhyme.

57. The third stanza's allusions are summed up in terms of

A) Art (line 16).
B) mediæval (line 23).
C) Medici (line 17).
D) Romance (line 15).
E) vagrant (line 16).

58. The fourth line of each stanza contributes to both a sense of Cheevy's tipsiness and his life's

A) iambic quality.
B) incompleteness.
C) lyric present.
D) quarrel with the ancients.
E) realism.

Items 59-60 refer to Arthur Guiterman's

The Vanity of Human Greatness

The tusks which clashed in mighty brawls
Of mastodons, are billiard balls.

The sword of Charlemagne the Just
Is Ferric Oxide, known as rust.

The grizzly bear, whose potent hug,
Was feared by all, is now a rug.

Great Caesar's bust is on the shelf,
And I don't feel so well myself.

59. The theme of Guiterman's lyric poem is the

A) certitude of change.
B) inevitably of death no matter who one is.
C) power of death over all mammals.
D) scarcity of living things among our collections.
E) offsetting of the truth of time by true rhyme.

60. The use of *tusks* for *mastodons* is an example of

A) ambiguity.
B) barbarism.
C) litotes.
D) prothesis.
E) synecdoche.

Items 61-65 refer to William Shakespeare's

Fear No More the Heat o' the Sun
from *Cymbeline* (4.2)

Fear no more the heat o' the sun,
Nor the furious winter's rages;
Thou thy worldly task hast done,
Home art gone, and ta'en thy wages:
Golden lads and girls all must,
As chimney-sweepers, come to dust.

Fear no more the frown o' the great;
Thou art past the tyrant's stroke;
Care no more to clothe and eat;
To thee the reed is as the oak:
The scepter, learning, physic, must
All follow this, and come to dust.

Fear no more the lightning flash,
Nor the all-dreaded thunder stone;
Fear not slander, censure rash;
Thou hast finished joy and moan:
All lovers young, all lovers must
Consign to thee, and come to dust.

No exorciser harm thee!
Nor no witchcraft charm thee!
Ghost unlaid forbear thee!
Nothing ill come near thee!
Quiet consummation have;
And renownèd be thy grave!

61. The theme of William Shakespeare's song, "Fear No More the Heat o' the Sun" is that

A) Æsop's wisdom is persistent.
B) death is inevitable.
C) global warming is a hoax.
D) home art is better than foreign art.
E) the only thing to fear is fear itself.

62. Line 11 (*scepter*, *learning*) features (a)

A) conceit.
B) metonymy.
C) palindrome.
D) syllepsis.
E) tapinosis.

63. Lines 5-6 address a range that is understood in terms of

A) class.
B) colour.
C) gender.
D) occupation.
E) youth.

64. Line 4's "Home" is given its denotative certitude in

A) line 8.
B) line 13.
C) line 14.
D) line 20.
E) line 24.

65. The mood of Shakespeare's song is, ultimately,

A) comforting.
B) dark.
C) flippant.
D) frightening.
E) morbid.

Required tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Garrison Keillor's "The Anthem," and address the nature of parody, especially in terms of your exposure to the Robert Frost canon.

The Anthem

[If Robert Frost had written "The Star-Spangled Banner"]

Whose flag is this I think I know
His house is being bombed now though
He will not see that I have come
To watch the twilight's ebbing glow.

My little horse must think it dumb,
The cannons' pandemonium,
The rockets bursting in the air,
The sound of bugle, fife, and drum.

He turns and shakes his derrière
To show me that he doesn't care
Who takes this battle flag or why,
When in the redness of the glare

I see the banner flying high
Through the tumult of the sky
And knowing all is now okay,
We walk away, my horse and I.

The flag is lovely, hip hooray,
But I have things to do today,
Some here and others far away,
Before I drop to hit the hay.

KEY

UIL Literary Criticism
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line arrows up ➔

1.	C	178
2.	C	605
3.	D	403
4.	B	573
5.	B	145
6.	D	283
7.	E	360
8.	A	
9.	E	571
10.	A	94
11.	D	208
12.	A	607
13.	D	588
14.	C	263
15.	B	215
16.	D	474
17.	A	582
18.	E	422
19.	C	315
20.	B	236
21.	E	492
22.	C	604
23.	B	222
24.	B	245
25.	B	279
26.	A	27
27.	D	431
28.	A	599
29.	C	335
30.	E	337
31.	A	38/108
32.	D	90-91
33.	D	54
34.	B	40
35.	C	127
36.	A	172
37.	E	470
38.	A	91
39.	D	120
40.	E	196
41.	C	173
42.	E	28, 56, 196, 207, 220
43.	C	
44.	E	445
45.	C	361
46.	B	173
47.	C	294
48.	D	
49.	D	
50.	E	
51.	A	75
52.	D	
53.	E	345
54.	C	
55.	C	
56.	A	196
57.	D	418
58.	B	
59.	B	
60.	E	
61.	B	
62.	B	298
63.	A	
64.	E	
65.	A	

FOLD
along the **three** longitudinal lines for ease in grading. ➔

Please note that the objective scores should not be altered to reflect the breaking of any ties. ***Simply adjust ranking***.

The thirty items in Part 1 are worth one point each.

The twenty items in Part 2 are worth two points each.

The fifteen items in Part 3 are worth two points each.

DO NOT
mark (cross out)
actual **LETTER** answer;
mark the answer **NUMERAL**.

Page numbers refer to the *Handbook* 12e,

the Simon & Schuster *Pygmalion*,

the Mariner-Houghton *The Things They Carried*,

and to Untermeyer's Frost collection.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Garrison Keillor's "The Anthem"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the parody that is Keillor's treatment of the Robert Frost canon include

allusion,	internal rhyme,	persona,
anaphora,	inversion,	personification,
anastrophe (hyperbaton),	long measure,	pun,
burlesque,	macaronic rhyme,	regionalism,
diction,	meter,	resolution,
enjambment,	mood,	run-on line,
heteromerous (mosaic) rhyme,	occasional verse,	stanza,
iambic tetrameter,	parody,	syntax, and
imagery,	pathetic fallacy,	tone.

The contestant might recall encountering Keillor's poem on the regional test (which does not constitute, at least in this instance, regionalism).

The writer might begin his or her discussion by pointing out that because Robert Frost's style is, in a sense, emulated, not ridiculed, the poem is not a burlesque (or a travesty)—and while the subject of the poem is, in a careful, light manner, lowered, it is not ridiculed.

Several aspects of the poem's form suggest something of a tribute to Frost's characteristic homage-without-obsequiousness to traditional prosody: the long measure's rhyme scheme is altered; the rhymes are playful (line 6's heteromerous rhyming with line 5, as well as line 9's macaronic, arguably, and heteromerous rhyming with "doesn't care"). Something might be made of Keillor's having choosen a four-line stanza over the five-line stanza of the Frost original, a choice that lightens the tone and, perhaps, reflects a bowing to the master in the manner that Virgil wrote his epic in twelve books not twenty-four, as had his own master, Homer.

The final stanza offers the writer the best point of departure, the connection with Frost's beloved "The Road Not Taken" being painfully obvious. The writer might deduce in the certitude of the persona's declaration "But I have things to do today" a contrast to Frost's ironic "I shall be telling this with a sigh / [. . .] / I took the one less traveled by [. . .]." That both recountings suggest "And that has made all the difference" (echoed in line 15's "all is now okay") contributes to parody's success.

Additionally, the writer might note that the play on the word *hay* might serve to balance—if not distract from—the pathetic fallacy that is the horse's (and, apparently, the persona's) turning his back, quite literally, on the significance of the event to which the original anthem and this parody are directed. Notwithstanding the characterization of patriotic revolution as pandemonium (a not-so-subtle allusion to Milton's Pandæmonium), the persona's distancing himself, with his horse, from the "tumult of the sky" suggests that things are, indeed, okay enough for both of them to rest contentedly on the farm, a setting that is immediately associated with Frost's regionalism.